FREE CHEAT SHEET

Japan Quick Start: Your First Trip on One Page

Simple tips for first-time visitors. Save it on your phone or print it.

Money

- Cards work at many hotels and big stores.
- Keep some yen as backup. Small shops may be cash only.
- Seven Bank ATMs accept many overseas-issued cards. Some cards may not work; fees apply.
- NEW **Tax-free from Nov 1, 2026:** pay the full price, then get the tax back when you leave. At the airport, do the tax-free check **before** checking in your bags.

Trains

- On supported local trains, tap a funded IC card (Suica, PASMO, ICOCA) at the gates when entering and exiting. Shinkansen and limited express trains require additional tickets or arrangements.
- Queue at the markings on the platform. Let people exit first.
- Avoid phone calls on local trains. Keep your voice low.

Eating Out

- Staff may ask how many people are in your group. Hold up fingers to show your group size.
- Water and wet hand towels (oshibori) are often free.
- Some ramen shops use ticket machines. Tipping is not expected.
- At many restaurants, you pay at the register.

Manners

- Remove your shoes where required, such as in homes and some traditional venues. Check signs or ask staff.
- Trash bins are rare on streets. Carry a small bag.
- On crowded trains, wear your backpack on the front.

6 Useful Japanese Phrases

Sumimasen	Excuse me / Sorry	**Kore, onegaishimasu**	This one, please
Arigatou gozaimasu	Thank you very much	**___ wa doko desu ka?**	Where is ___?
Ikura desu ka?	How much is it?	**Daijoubu desu**	I'm okay / No thank you (depends on context)

Emergency **110** Police **119** Fire / Ambulance

Rules vary by place. Follow local signs and staff instructions.

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